

KF Overview of Romans

During this eight-week study we will look at Romans as members of Karis Fellowships. In KF we learn to understand the Bible in terms of our purpose which is to liberate and empower the True Self, declaring God's glory through our lives, and living in harmony with a material Creation. I will not go over the history of the letter to the Romans except to say that we will be approaching this letter as if we are reading Paul's ideas for the first time. After all, this is how those in first century Roman first understood this letter. We will jettison our preconceived ideas of what certain words mean and what we have been previously taught about this letter. Romans is confusing for us because we live in another age, culture, and language than Paul. We cannot possibly hear this letter exactly as the Romans did, but we can open our minds to the letter as they did, without preconceived ideas and orthodox interpretations. For centuries, people have been studying the Bible and then applying it to the ever-changing panorama of cultures and civilizations. No culture or group has the Bible all figured out, yet every culture can understand and apply the Bible in a way that encourages their spiritual development and their understanding of God. This is what makes Christianity so flexible and healing for every generation. The Bible is a marvelous and dynamic book that never stops surprising us or speaking to us. I hope that you will experience some surprises in this study of Romans.

I would like to remind you again that Karis Fellowships is not a church or a school of theology. We are a group of Christians who are in training to develop our unique created design and mission. The KF Romans study will present an alternative way to think about what that means. Our application of KF concepts to Romans is not right or wrong. I am simply presenting an alternative way to understand what Paul is saying. I hope that this alternative understanding will enrich whatever experience you now have with Romans. However, from my own experience with Romans I have come to believe that this alternative understanding is more consistent with Paul's entire argument and teachings. Each chapter builds on the previous one and Paul expects us to remember what he has already said. There are no breaks or deviations from the logical progression of his argument.

I developed this study from months of Greek tutoring with a marvelous teacher and comparative language scholar, Dr. Laura Gibbs. She continues to serve the academic community through her classes on-line and her websites. I was given one of the greatest karis gifts of my life when in 2005 she sat down with a small group of us and helped us read through Romans. Her understanding of the culture and the language revealed Romans as I had never heard it before in all the decades that I have studied this letter. I applied my understanding of *Neurosis and Human Growth* to Romans and the tectonic shift in my own soul toward the birth of Karis Fellowships began.

I want to point you in the basic direction of this road through Romans. During the next eight weeks, we will be actually walking that road. I hope that you will enjoy the many vistas and details along the way even while you struggle to grasp a new way of thinking about your Christian life.

In the first chapter we learn about two different kinds of relationships. One is built on calling which is an invitation to be together. The other is built on separation, or a choice to be alone. One is an active, dynamic and productive state, producing fruit in our lives. Separation on the other hand causes stagnation, and produces death.

After we have the pleasure of judging the people Paul describes in the first chapter of Romans, he throws a bucket of ice-water on us in the second. Paul accuses us of separation and stagnation. You will see this pattern over and over again in Romans. Paul sets us up to feel comfortable about our judgments, and then like an expert in judo, flips us over on our backs and turns our judgments on ourselves. Stagnation is not about those people out there. It is about you. He explains how, in order to manage our stagnating separation, we have developed and now fiercely adhere to legal systems, or our own personal law. We judge and are judged with unfair partialities based on our shoulds and claims. With judgment comes wrath. In our judgment we have forgotten that God is the only one qualified to judge by law. His laws are completely impartial, meaning that no one, no matter their status, position, family antecedents, race, or religion, gets away with anything according to law. Do we really want to keep living under law?

By chapter 3 we realize that everyone is misoriented. Everyone has adopted a law of some kind in order to manage their deep stagnating disease of separation from the Creator. We might look at this law as an honor or shame system. We live in chronic anxiety. The law supports our pride and when it is violated, this law generates self-hate. Perhaps we are ready to let go of our legal systems.

Out of the despair of chapter 3 we are introduced to a different way of managing our separation from ourselves, others, and God. Paul tells us that there is another way to righteousness or orientation. It is the path of faith or trust. I would like you to start thinking this way. Rather than our old concepts of faith, let's try to replace the word *faith* with the word *trust* or *trustworthiness*. Orientation, or righteousness, simply means that God can trust us. God and we are on the same page when it comes to our values, behavior, and attitudes. We are congruent with Him and His way of doing things. We find out in this chapter that there are two laws or legal systems at work. One is about rules and the other is about trust. One ends in death and the other results in life. We will learn that law has never built relationships with anyone and that trust has always been the system that God prefers. That is what chapter 4 is about.

From another perspective, in chapter 5, Paul compares these two laws which result in death or life with the examples of Adam and Jesus. Adam began separation and the need to have some kind of restraining law. That system leads to death. Jesus began the system of trust which leads to life and freedom. We work toward possibilities. We are no longer motivated by the fear of punishment. More than this, we have a choice about by which system we want to live our lives.

Paul invites us to choose life. In chapters 6 and 7 we learn about our freedom from rules. He compares the life of law to the lives of women and slaves. People under law live in the terror of punishment. By describing a condition that everyone in Paul's culture understood, he invites us to let go of our slavery to our Idol Self, our terror of its wrath, and to give up maintaining our pride with legal systems. We stop being weapons of destruction in this world. We enter into the voluntary slavery of our original design as servants of God our Creator. We are His creatures, valued members of His household, where there thrives a *karis* relationship which cancels out all legal systems. We become weapons of orientation in our own lives and in the world around us. The foundation of that *karis* relationship is trust. Love has banished all fear. The circulation of *karis* moves us out of stagnation and into ever deepening trust, security, and bold confidence.

The Holy Spirit is like a family bloodline to God. God's Spirit makes us family. In the beginning, families teach children rules, but when the children are older they learn to be trustworthy in relationship. The laws no longer apply. Chapter 8 describes our birth into this new system of trustworthy relationship. The Creation supports our birth by the material events and trials in our lives. No birth is easy, and we are necessarily uncomfortable in the process. God extends a *karis* invitation to those who are willing to

participate in the birthing process. His karis is not partial or selective based on position, race, education, or prestige. It is based on the personal effort to respond.

Chapters 9 and 10 handle the great anxiety and horror that people of all cultures feel when they hear that their legal systems and partiality are not the methods by which God chooses His relationships. For them, this is a cultural and neurotic impossibility! Paul, with some sorrow, tells us that God's choice of karis is true, however. Can you imagine the great insecurity of suddenly being told that no amount of entitlements based on birth or position, of following your own law, or of controlling others will get you any partiality from God? It can't be true! And yet, God, who is the only real judge, has chosen karis over law.

God calls all people into the karis relationship in chapter 11. He lays down the karis path of how we are to engage with Him. He trains us to be trustworthy. In chapter 12, we are allowed just a glimpse of what our karis response will be that no law can dictate. This is an absolutely incredible understanding, that we actually have something splendidly precious to offer to God. He has been longing for that gift from every human being in every culture and for all time.

Chapters 13 through 16 describe details of how the karis relationship works out in our community and fellowship, but we will not continue our study into these chapters. You can read them for yourself and see how Paul continues to teach us how to live in karis.

I am looking forward to sharing Paul's great letter with you.